

Sony LinkBuds Open

Striking a balance between concept and execution

Sony's foray into the open-style earbud market continues with the LinkBuds Open, a follow-up to the original LinkBuds. While their predecessor introduced an unconventional design, the new iteration refines the concept further. The result is an intriguing product aimed at listeners who prioritise environmental awareness over isolation. But how does this approach fare in terms of practicality, sound quality, and overall value? Let's find out!

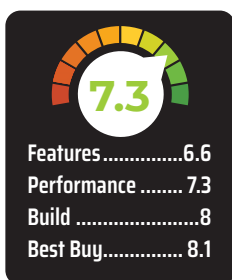
BUILD AND DESIGN

Sony is no stranger to pushing boundaries in design, and the LinkBuds Open is a testament to this. These earbuds deviate from the conventional "in-ear" or "over-ear" styles, opting instead for a circular open-ring design that rests just outside the ear canal. This unique build ensures that users remain aware of their surroundings, a feature ideal for outdoor activities like jogging or commuting.

Despite their unorthodox appearance, the build quality feels premium. The earbuds are lightweight yet sturdy, with an IPX4 rating for water and sweat resistance – a must-have for folks who are planning to rock these during their workouts. However, the fit can be a mixed bag. While some may find the ergonomic shape comfortable, others might struggle with stability during vigorous movements. Sony provides multiple ear wing sizes, but the universal fit still leans heavily on personal preference.

The charging case is compact and sleek, though it lacks wireless charging—a curious omission at this

₹18,990



price point. The magnetic latch is secure, ensuring that the earbuds stay in place, but the lack of a proper indicator for battery levels on the case itself feels like a missed opportunity.

FEATURES AND CONNECTIVITY

On the feature front, the LinkBuds Open offers a mix of hits and misses. Sony's focus on transparency and environmental awareness comes through with the Adaptive Ambient Sound mode, which dynamically adjusts based on your surroundings. This feature works seamlessly and is one of the earbuds' strongest selling points.

The earbuds support Bluetooth 5.3, ensuring a stable and efficient connection. Pairing is a breeze, thanks to

Google Fast Pair and Microsoft Swift Pair integration. However, codec support is limited to SBC and AAC, leaving out high-resolution options like LDAC. For a product aimed at audiophiles and casual listeners alike, this limitation could be a deal-breaker.

Touch controls are intuitive – even with the Wide Area Tap – and customisable via the Sony Headphones Connect app. Functions such as playback control, volume adjustment, and access to voice assistants can be assigned based on user preference. Additionally, the Speak-to-Chat feature – a carryover from Sony's premium models – pauses playback when you start speaking, enhancing convenience for quick interactions.

PERFORMANCE

The sound profile of the LinkBuds Open is where opinions may diverge. These earbuds are tailored for users who prioritise ambient awareness, which means bass response and noise isolation take a backseat. The soundstage is wide and airy, delivering excellent clarity in the mid and high frequencies. Vocals and instruments come through with precision, making them well-suited for genres like classical, jazz, and podcasts.

However, bass heads may find the performance underwhelming. The open design naturally limits low-end extension, and even with EQ tweaks via the app, the sub-bass remains subdued. This isn't necessarily a flaw but rather a consequence of the earbuds' design philosophy.

Call quality is impressive, with dual noise-sensing microphones effectively isolating your voice in noisy environments. Whether you're in a bustling cafe or on a busy street, the LinkBuds Open ensures that your voice remains clear to the person on the other end.

The LinkBuds Open excels in scenarios where environmental awareness is crucial. For cyclists, joggers, or commuters, the open-ring design provides a perfect blend of audio enjoyment and situational awareness. The lightweight